

The Ingenious Machine

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Chapter Fourteen: The Island of Good Administration

Santa Rita sent for Chano because residents had continued asking for him after the town stopped employing him. The system had classified this as demand for a discontinued service.

Irma's signed invitation offered a temporary appointment with specified authority over emergency allocations, a budget, and staff to receive disputed cases. The salary was attractive. A separate letter from Castalia offered to withdraw its own complaint if he accepted the appointment. Chano sent the second letter to the adviser and negotiated the job without treating it as immunity from every other proceeding.

"They want you to make the lie run better," Lucía said.

"I want to make the water run."

"They can put that in the brochure too."

"Then they can print it while the truck is moving."

Q asked whether Chano wanted him to come. He did not. He wanted Q to remain available for a particular comparison of route records if he asked for it.

"They asked for me," Chano said. "I don't want to arrive as your local difficulty."

"All right," Q said. "I'll wait for the request."

"You make waiting sound busy."

"I can put it on the list without sending it to you every morning."

Chano took the appointment terms, the copies residents had authorized him to use, and a new notebook. His original ledger was still retained in Tijuana. The recovery request continued through Elena; accepting another job did not close that request.

Irma remained mayor. His badge read **COMMUNITY VARIANCE OFFICER**, a title that could either authorize exceptions or make a man responsible for the fact that people varied. He asked which before signing the final terms. He received a schedule of delegated powers and an escalation contact. He expected to use both.



They asked for me

At the settlement, Maribel showed him a temporary fence diverting the walking route to the clinic. A contractor had left it around a work area after the work was suspended. The official alternative added a long walk to a journey people already made unwell.

Chano called the municipal works supervisor. The supervisor confirmed which section could be reopened safely and sent a crew. Irma approved the access arrangement under the temporary appointment. The dashboard continued to display the old route until a clerk updated the closure.

“Which one counts?” Maribel asked, pointing to the screen and then the opening in the fence.

“For getting to the clinic, this one. For making somebody pay the crew, I'll have to finish with that one.”

He did. The opening remained after the first photograph of him beside it had ceased to interest the publicity office.

The water allocation went less well. Chano approved an extra tanker run to the settlement

using a roster that omitted a recurring clinic delivery. By the time Rosa, the dispatcher, reached him, the driver was unloading at the settlement.

“Where is the clinic's truck?” she asked.

“On the extra run. There was nothing after eleven.”

“On that screen.”

She laid the standing schedule beside it. Chano found the clinic entry, then his own approval on the revised route.

“Can he go there next?”

“After refilling. I've asked him. They need to know how late.”

He called the clinic director with Rosa's estimate, then called again when the refill took longer. The residents got their water; the clinic received its delivery late. When he apologized, the director asked which number she should call next time. He gave her his and Rosa's.

“Mine first for dispatch,” Rosa said. “His if you need an apology.”

Chano entered the actual arrival time. Rosa put the standing commitments beside the new



On that screen

requests on the planning sheet and made him check both.

The complaint portal yielded thousands of entries, many duplicates, some old, and some urgent. He kept it open for submissions, suspended the automated replies that marked cases settled without review, and opened a room for people who could not use it. A clerk linked repeated entries so the same complaint did not consume six places in the queue. People who disputed a link could have it checked.

Nereida arrived with a water meter wrapped in a dish towel. A repair worker had replaced it months earlier. The old serial number still appeared on her bill, while the new one was attached to another property. She had photographs, the repair receipt, and two demands for payment.

“They asked me to bring proof,” she said. “It was heavy.”

Chano compared the numbers with the clerk. They requested a correction and a hold on the disputed charge pending review. Nereida wanted to know whether she could leave the meter there.

The clerk gave her an item receipt rather than asking her to carry it home until the office had learned to trust a photograph.

A teacher came about a bus diverted to another neighborhood. She did not call its passengers the wrong children. They needed a bus too. She wanted the removed service restored without pretending a full vehicle proved the original route had been served.

The available options had costs: another driver, a longer circuit, or a changed start time that would burden families. Chano asked the schools and drivers to examine them together. The first proposal failed because it required the same vehicle in two places at once. No amount of public consultation made that arrangement more generous.

He called Q for the route comparison they had discussed. Q put the two versions side by side. The revised plan no longer required the bus in two places, but its journey time still matched a drive without stops.

“Has anyone timed this with the pickups?” he asked.



Rosa called the driver over. The driver named three stops missing from the line on the map. One required a longer loop because the bus could not turn at the end of the lane.

“It fits if we leave those children behind,” Chano said.

“Then we’ve found what made it fit,” Q said. “Let’s put them back.”

He added the stops as the driver described them. They checked the new duration against the driver’s last run, and Chano chose an interim extra trip using the budget he controlled. The driver asked who would pay the additional hours. Chano entered those before calling either school. The permanent decision still needed funding.

Fermín brought a notice assigning his daughter a risk flag after a period of absence from school. Her mother had died. He wanted the flag challenged, not his daughter’s grief displayed as a case for the crowd. The clerk received the papers privately and explained who would review the disputed inference. Chano asked for a response date and an

interim limit on use of the flag while it was contested.

The model had found a pattern. People had decided what consequences to attach to it. Chano wanted those decisions named in the answer.

Near noon the clinic director came with another problem. A supply delivery was delayed after a forecasting rule reduced its transport allowance. Lower reported demand had been treated as a reason to cut the service that helped keep demand manageable. She brought the unfilled request and waited while he called the transport office.

Chano confirmed the transport needs with her and used the emergency allocation he had been given. The delivery reached the clinic. He entered the request reference and the route in the log; in his own notebook he wrote that an improvement could be destroyed by deciding it no longer needed to be maintained.

Leticia arrived with the cleaning crew’s proposed routes. The model sent them repeatedly through the busiest plazas and left outlying streets waiting.



Put the stops back

Their older schedule had problems too.

“We can restore it for now,” Chano said.

“And review the part we used to complain about,” she replied.

“I was hoping to admire the old arrangement for an entire afternoon.”

“You can admire it while reading page two.”

Someone brought bread. Nereida set the wrapped meter beneath a chair, where it would not damage the papers. Children drew on scrap sheets, not rejected forms still carrying other families' information. One gave the dashboard a hat so it would look as if it knew where it was going. Chano asked whether the hat could be issued to staff.

His first week produced real changes and an increasing pile of work. The dashboard's public summary counted the restored delivery and omitted the failed one. It counted completed contacts as resolved complaints. Chano requested the categories be separated. The software could display them separately; the contractor's published measure

and the ministry's reporting form still demanded the old aggregate.

Irma arrived for the review with the original model specification. It gave some of the definitions Chano had been unable to obtain in his first appointment. Notes from an earlier pilot warned that lack of response could be misread as agreement. A later implementation had nevertheless closed cases after a period without replies.

“Silence is cheaper than finding out why no one answered,” Chano said.

“It was sold as a way to stop staff keeping cases open for bribes,” Irma replied.

The system had reduced some theft and made payments easier to trace. Residents remembered the earlier administrations, too. Leticia did not want cash envelopes restored as a form of human discretion. Fermín wanted a human answer with a record of who gave it. Neither request required choosing between the entire old system and the entire new one.

Chano proposed publishing the definitions and aggregate



A hat for the dashboard

correction, keeping personal case files with the authorized reviewers. Irma agreed to a release of the relevant specification pages. The contractor objected that the correction would invalidate the performance claim on which its payment depended. That objection finally made the meeting's attention settle on the same number.

The next morning his account would not open. The clerk brought the suspension notice: allocations and reporting under review. Irma's signature was at the bottom.

He found her beside the meeting room, holding a cup whose coffee had gone cold during a call from the ministry.

"The contractor asked for this?"

"And the ministry. They want the figure left alone until the payment review. Half my committee won't approve the next allocation without it."

"But that's your signature."

"Yes."

"You asked me to identify errors," Chano said.

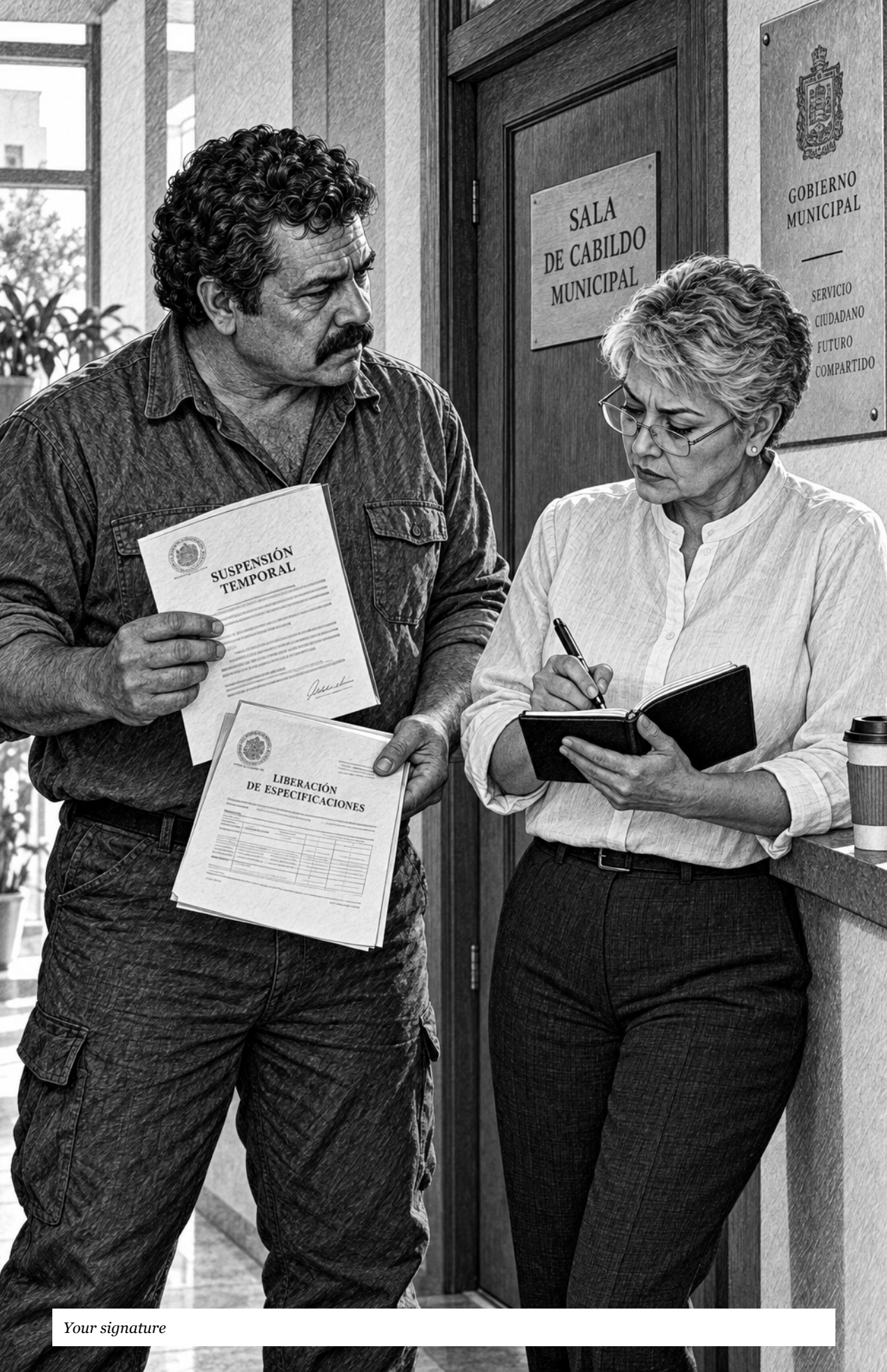
"I expected us to agree how to report them."

"We did. You agreed to these pages."

He kept her signed release with the specification. She did not retract it. She asked whether the temporary bus run would survive until the review. He showed her the funded dates. She copied the last one into her diary and went back into the meeting. His account remained closed.

Security staff attended the handover of keys and municipal equipment. The police waited outside because someone had reported an impending occupation. Residents were meeting to choose who would follow their pending cases. Authorized contacts received their own case receipts; the working files stayed with the responsible office under a documented handover.

Chano took his personal notebook, permitted copies, the released specification pages, and a list of outstanding commitments he was allowed to retain. The list did not authorize him to publish every name on it.



Your signature

He told the residents who was to answer next, where he could still be reached, and what he had not managed to do.

“Did anything work?” a journalist asked at the gate.

“The clinic gate is open. The extra bus is funded until the review. Some bills are being corrected. The reporting dispute is not resolved.”

“Was it a success?”

“I just gave you more than one answer.”

Q and Lucía met him at the bus station under Q's accompanied-visit arrangement. He handed Lucía the public specification extract and showed Q the version of the route plan the dispatcher had confirmed.

“Your second island,” Q said.

“It had mainland prices.”

“Do you want it in the book?”

“Yes. Include the tanker I sent late.”

Q wrote that down.

“And the one that arrived on time,” Chano added.

“Both.”

“Don't make the second one the lesson I learned from the first.”

“I won't give the tanker a character arc.”

“Good. It has a route.”

Q left space between the two entries.

“Do I have to explain the week before we eat?” Chano asked.

“I've imagined three lunches on that bus.”

“Let's see if they've imagined any of them here.” Q closed the notebook.

Beyond the exit, a woman was lifting the lid of a pot. Chano went to ask what she still had. Lucía tucked the specification into her bag and followed him. Q came with them.

Interlude: The Chair of Governance

Chano did not take Santa Rita's office chair when he left. This fact requires stating because he spent enough time considering it to furnish a less scrupulous historian with a motive, an opportunity, and several paragraphs of defense.



A route, not an arc

It had five wheels, a cracked armrest, and a hydraulic column that sank when he attempted a particularly authoritative posture. The chair had introduced doubt into more meetings than the opposition. He grew fond of it.

During his appointment he moved it to the complaint room when somebody needed a seat with arms. Leticia later used it at the reception desk. The inventory still placed it in the officer's room. An automated audit reported it missing.

Chano asked the clerk to change the location. The maintenance request attached to the chair complicated the transfer: the contractor was expected to collect it from its old room. A second employee had already been assigned to investigate why it was missing there.

“Can those two appointments meet each other?” Chano asked.

The clerk called the contractor. The older of the two men who arrived needed to sit while his colleague compared the labels. Chano offered him the chair. It sank with the dignity of an

institution accepting a reduction in its budget.

“Column needs replacing,” the older man said.

“That is also my assessment of the office,” Chano replied.

The replacement part could wait a week. The contractor could leave the chair for seated use with a note about the fault, provided the municipality accepted that arrangement. The clerk obtained the sign-off and corrected the collection location. Nobody needed to pretend the chair was inaccessible in order to prevent its useful presence from becoming a missing asset.

Leticia wanted it to remain at the complaint desk after repair. Chano wanted it back in his office. He could explain both desires in terms of public service. The chair's effect on his own back made the second explanation especially fluent.

He called Q during their scheduled route discussion and asked how to record the move without claiming authority to give the chair away.



The sinking office

“You're changing its assigned use within the municipality?” Q asked.

“If they'll approve it.”

“Then use that request. Keep the inventory number, proposed room, and approver. Don't turn it into a donation.”

“No shared-use constitution?”

“Only if the chair disputes the room.”

Chano put the phone on speaker with the others' agreement.

Leticia said the chair had made fewer objections than he had. Q accepted that as the end of his contribution and returned to the bus timings.

Irma approved the assignment to the complaint desk before suspending Chano's credentials. That left the chair where people had been using it and deprived him of the pleasure of taking it away as an act of defiance. He found this surprisingly difficult to celebrate.

On his last evening he sat in it after the room emptied. The lowered seat put his eyes level with the requests stacked on the desk. He had liked being listened

to from the higher position. That admission did not make the open clinic gate false. It did make it harder to write that he had wanted nothing for himself.

He left the chair's inventory number with Leticia and returned the office keys. She asked whether he wanted a photograph of himself beside it. He said no, then asked her to let him know if the part arrived. She promised she would.

Much later, the chair reached the archive through a documented surplus sale after the complaint room obtained replacements. Its remaining good wheel had been exchanged with another chair; the invoice described the resulting collection as furniture. Chano bought the part it still needed and repaired it in the workshop.

“You got the office in the end,” Lucía said.

“Only the part that ever supported me.”

She sat in it. It held its height. Chano looked pleased in a way no account of municipal disappointment was entitled to correct.



The part that supported him

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